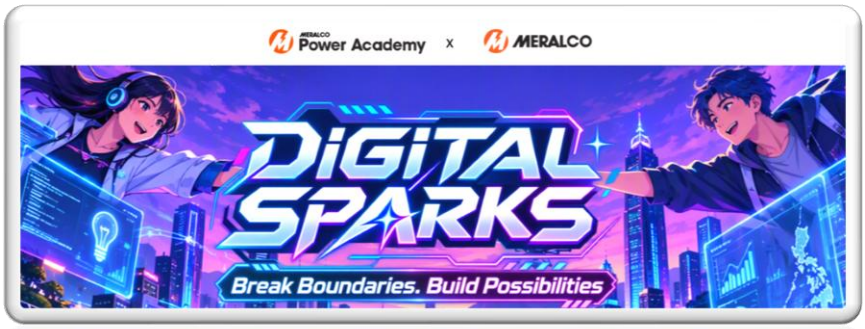


IDOL HACKATHON 2026 – MECHANICS AND GUIDELINES

I. Team Composition

- The Program is open to students who are currently:
  a. Undergraduates (no existing bachelor's degree); and
  b. Enrolled senior high school and college students aged 18 and above (by date of application) from reputable educational institutions.
- Participants must form teams consisting of a minimum of two (2) and a maximum of five (5) members.

II. Qualifying Phase

- In the Hackathon Qualifying Phase, the participants must submit their proposal to participate in the Hackathon proper to hackathon@meralcopoweracademy.org with the subject "IDOL HACKATHON 2026 PROPOSAL - (GROUPNAME)".

- The proposal must be a 1-page PDF document that includes problem statement and a proposed solution that demonstrates your ability to identify challenges, think critically, and develop innovative approaches. The document should be in a readable format with a minimum font size of 10.
  IMPORTANT: The proposal submitted during registration is for evaluation purposes only. Selected participants will receive the official hackathon challenge statements and choose one challenge to address during the hackathon.

- Last day for submission of proposals will be on October 23, 2026 until 11:59 PM only, unless otherwise advised by the Organizers.

- Proposals will be reviewed and evaluated by the Organizer. The top 10 teams will advance to the Hackathon Proper.

- Results of the proposal screening will be released on November 4, 2026 via email.

- Qualified teams are expected to be ready for the 2-day Hackathon from November 12, 2026 to November 13, 2026.

III. Hackathon Proper

Date: November 12 - 13, 2026 (Round-The-Clock)

GENERAL RULES

- This is a face-to-face event; all team members must be physically present at the venue with complete registration (this includes Application Form, Student Verification document/s and signed TERMS and Privacy Notice and Consent during the application process).
- Registration begins at 7:30 AM. Please arrive no later than 8:15 AM.
- Participants will receive the official hackathon challenge statements and choose one challenge to address during the hackathon.
- Participants may not join more than one team or submit more than one entry per team.

HACKATHON RULES

- All source code must be written between November 12, 9:00 AM to November 13, 9:00 AM.
- Participants are allowed to install software, plan their projects, and gather data sets in advance, but coding and/or assembly of hardware components must only occur during the Hackathon period.
- Teams can use publicly available libraries, packages, design assets, and APIs. Any additional assets used during the event must be approved by the Organizers.
- Submissions must include all relevant files (e.g. GitHub repository link) and be completed before November 13, 9:30AM. Late submissions will not be accepted.
- Coaches will be available for mentorship and support.
- Participants may leave the venue, but at least one representative must remain present at the venue throughout the hacking period.
- All devices related to the Hackathon Project must be left at the premises if the participants leave the venue.

GROUNDS FOR DISQUALIFICATION

- Plagiarism
- Violation of event policies, terms, and conditions
- Breach of data ethics standards, data privacy, or security protocols

IV. Judging Criteria

Presentation:

- Teams will present their projects in a dedicated area.
- Each team will have up to 15 minutes to present; 10 minutes for actual presentation, and 5 minutes for judges to ask their questions and for the team or participants to answer them (Q&A).
- The project pitch should be focused on a working demonstration of the project.

Criteria	Weight	Description
Innovation	30%	How original and creative is the solution? Does it introduce fresh ideas or concepts that differentiate it from existing solutions? Does it approach the problem in an unconventional way that offers a unique perspective or methodology? The degree of innovation should reflect novelty, originality, and inventive thinking.
Functionality	25%	How well does the solution work in practice? Is it fully operational and free from critical errors or bugs? Does it meet the objectives and perform the required tasks efficiently? The evaluation focuses on the solution's reliability, stability, and overall user experience.
Impact	20%	How meaningful is the solution's potential to create positive change? Does it address a significant real-world problem or societal need? Is there a clear demonstration of how it could benefit individuals, communities, or industries on a local or global scale? Impact should be assessed based on its practical value and potential reach.
Technical Challenge	15%	How sophisticated was the solution to build? Does the implementation demonstrate advanced technical skills, creativity in applying technology, or problem-solving? Was the solution developed using a high degree of technical expertise, and does it efficiently address difficult challenges with innovative techniques or algorithms?
Presentation	10%	How effectively was the solution communicated to the audience? Was the pitch structured clearly, concise, and engaging? Did the presentation successfully highlight the key features, benefits, and impact of the solution? The assessment should consider the clarity of delivery, visual aids, storytelling, and ability to answer questions convincingly.

AWARDING CEREMONIES

Awarding will commence on **November 24, 2026**, during the Innovation Awards Culminating event. Winning teams will receive an invitation to the awarding ceremony.

WE RECOMMEND THAT THE PARTICIPANTS BRING THE FOLLOWING:

- Tumbler
- Medicines/supplements
- Extra clothes

Important Reminder: *Single-Use Plastics (SUPs) are strictly prohibited. This sustainability guideline covers all offices and facilities of Meralco.*